by a scenic ferry ride, making the journey to the caves an experience in itself.
How to go: Road: Mumbai – 21.9 km | Rail: Mumbai – 25 km | Ferry Services are available from Gateway of India

KARLA CAVES, Pune
Located in Lonavla, the Karla Caves date back to between the 2nd century BCE and the 5th century CE. These caves represent the pinnacle of rock-cut architecture of their time. The Grand Chaitya, one of the largest Chaityagrihas (Buddhist prayer halls), is particularly notable for its intricate artwork. Visitors can access these caves by hiking up 350 steps, where they are welcomed by a beautiful horseshoe-shaped entrance and exquisite craftsmanship.
How to go: Road: Mumbai - 94 km | Rail: Lonavala – 11 km
Nearby Sights: Bhaja Caves, Nasik Caves, Bhushi Dam, Ekvira Devi Temple, Lohagad Fort.

BEDSE CAVES, Pune
Situated in the Maval taluka of Pune District, the Bedse Caves date back to the 1st century BCE and were used by Buddhist monks for meditation and religious activities. The larger cave, known as the Chaitya, features a grand horseshoe-shaped entrance with intricately carved columns and a stupa surrounded by a circular path for circumambulation. The smaller Vihara cave served as a monastic residence. Despite their relative obscurity, the Bedse Caves offer a glimpse into ancient Buddhist architecture and art.
How to go: Road: Mumbai - 107 km | Rail: Lonavala – 26 km
Nearby Sights: Lonavala Hill Station, Kamshet Waterfall, Visapur Fort, Lohagad Fort, Tung Fort.

BHAJA CAVES, Pune
Located in Maval taluka, the Bhaja Caves belong to the Theravada tradition of Buddhism and are among the oldest in Western India. The site features a Chaityagriha with 27 pillars and a complex of Viharas and Stupas.
How to go: Road: Mumbai – 95.4 km | Rail: Malavali – 3 km
Nearby Sights: Karla Caves, Narayani Dham Temple, Lonavala, Lohagad Fort, Visapur Fort.

GANDHARPALE CAVES, Raigad
Situated near Mahad, the Gandharpale Caves date back to the early centuries of the Common Era. The site includes 30 caves carved out in three different layers of volcanic rock, featuring Chaityas and Viharas. The site's inscriptions and archaeological evidence suggest that Buddhist monks lived here until the 7th-8th century CE.
How to go: Road: Mumbai - 169 km | Rail: Mangoan – 27 km
Nearby Sights: Chavdar Lake, Mahendragad Fort, Raigad Fort, Kol Caves.

KUDA CAVES, Raigad
The Kuda Caves in Raigad were carved during the initial centuries of the Common Era and later adorned with Buddha images in the 6th century. The site includes 26 caves patronized by local kings, nobles, and traders, featuring early regional art and modest viharas.
How to go: Road: Mumbai - 147 km | Rail: Kolad – 30 km
Nearby Sights: Tala Fort, Murud Janjira Fort, Diveagar Beach, Kashid Beach, Kolad River Rafting.

PANHALE KAJI CAVES, Ratnagiri
Located in Ratnagiri, the Panhale Kaji Caves date back to the 3rd century AD. This site includes a mix of early Buddhist caves and later esoteric Buddhist modifications, with rare sculptures and structural remains.
How to go: Road: Mumbai - 251 km | Rail: Khed – 27 km
Nearby Sights: Dabhol Jetty, Keshavraj Temple, Unhavare Hot water springs.

AJANTA AND ELLORA CAVES, Aurangabad
The Ajanta and Ellora Caves are exemplary of rock-cut architecture and are adorned with intricate carvings, statues of the Buddha, and elaborate frescoes depicting Jataka tales and other Buddhist narratives. These caves, serving as centers of worship, teaching, and community life, provide profound insights into early Buddhist culture and artistic heritage.
The Ellora Caves are a testament to the harmonious blend of Hindu, Buddhist, and Jain religious traditions. The complex consists of 34 major caves, including the famous Kailash Temple, a monolithic structure dedicated to Lord Shiva. The Hindu caves (13-29) feature elaborate sculptures and carved panels, while the Buddhist caves (1-12) include prayer halls and monasteries.
How to go: Road: Mumbai - 319 km | Rail: Aurangabad – 28 km | Air: Aurangabad
**Distance Between Ajanta Caves and Ellora Caves is approx. 110 km by Road.*
Nearby Sights: Grishneshwar Temple, Bibi Ka Maqbara, Aurangabad Caves, Daulatabad Fort, Khuldabad Village & Tomb Of Aurangzeb, Aurangabad Wineries.

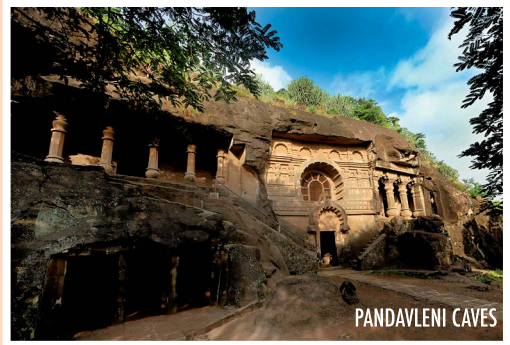
PITALKHORA CAVES, Aurangabad
Situated in Aurangabad, the Pitalkhora Caves date back to the 2nd century BCE and were used as monastic retreats and meditation centers. The complex consists of about 14 caves, featuring intricate carvings and sculptures of Buddhist deities. The serene and picturesque setting of these caves adds to their allure, making them a significant archaeological site.
How to go: Road: Mumbai - 363 km | Rail: Jalgoan – 59 km
Nearby Sights: Pitalkhora View Point, Gautala Autramghat Sanctuary, Sir Autram Smarak, Ellora Caves.

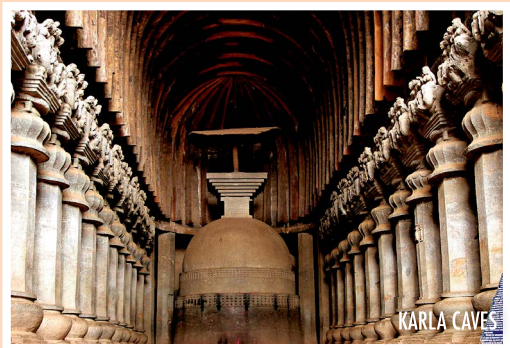
GHATOTKACHA CAVES, Aurangabad
Near the village of Jinjala, the Ghatotkacha Caves are contemporary to the Ajanta caves. These caves feature 22 line inscriptions mentioning Varahadeva, a minister of Vakataka King Harisena. The Vihara cave includes 20 octagonal pillars forming a square and three shrines, with the central shrine housing a statue of Buddha in Dharmachakra Pravartana Mudra.
How to go: Road: Mumbai - 412 km | Rail: Jinjala Village – 18 km
Nearby Sights: Pitalkhora Caves, Vetalwadi Fort, Ellora Caves, Ajanta Caves, Jinjala Fort, Jinjala Jama Masjid.

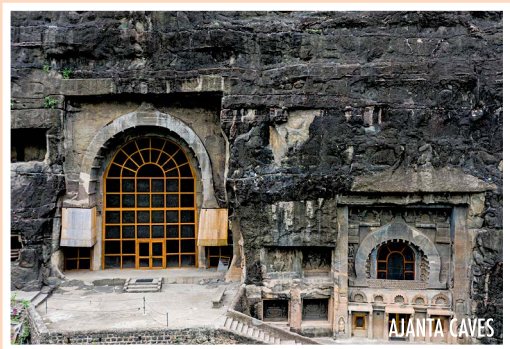
AURANGABAD CAVES, Aurangabad
The Aurangabad Caves, excavated during the 6th and 7th centuries, showcase a blend of Buddhist, Hindu, and Jain architectural styles. Comprising 12 caves, the site features intricate carvings and sculptures, including Cave 7 with a tiger frieze and Cave 10 with figures of Bodhisattvas. The caves are part of a UNESCO World Heritage Site, offering insights into ancient Indian art and culture.
How to go: Road: Mumbai - 327 km | Rail: Aurangabad – 8.8 km | Air: Aurangabad
Nearby Sights: Aurangaba Jain Temple, Chhatrapati Shivaji Museum.

PANDAVLENI CAVES, Nashik
Located on the Trirashmi Hills in Nashik, the Pandavleni Caves date back to the 1st century BCE and consist of 24 caves. Originally used as viharas (monasteries), these caves feature intricate carvings, sculptures, and inscriptions depicting various Buddhist deities and scenes from the life of Buddha. The main cave, Cave 3, is particularly impressive with its grand chaitya.
How to go: Road: Mumbai - 159 km | Rail: Nashik – 10 km
Nearby Sights: Sarkar Wada, Trimbakeshwar Temple, Gangapur Dam, Sula Vineyards.


BHAJA CAVES


PANDAVLENI CAVES


KARLA CAVES


AJANTA CAVES

DHARASHIV CAVES, Dharashiv
Located in Osmanabad, the Dharashiv Caves date back to the 8th to 9th centuries. This complex of about 14 caves includes notable features such as Cave 6, with a large sculpture of Buddha, and Cave 7, with a seated Buddha. These caves provide insights into Buddhist culture and art of the period.
How to go: Road: Mumbai - 409 km | Rail: Dharashiv – 7 km
Nearby Sights: Garad Garden, Hatla Devi Hill Station, Ramlingappa Lamture Government Museum, Ghatshil Temple, Aai Yedeshwari Temple, Javalgoan Dam, Ausa Fort, Paranda Fort, Tuljapur Temple.

The caves of Maharashtra stand as timeless witnesses to the region's rich and diverse heritage, inviting us to embark on a journey through time and immerse ourselves in their enduring beauty and significance.